

PITCHING

Inspiring people to give you money

| NEWS: COOK → TERNUS

Tim Cook steps down. **John Ternus** (25 years at Apple, SVP Hardware Engineering) becomes CEO effective **Sept 1, 2026**. Cook moves to Executive Chairman. Market cap under Cook: **\$350B → \$4T** over 15 years.

DISCUSSION

- 1 **Why a hardware engineer**, not a product or finance person?
- 2 **What kind of leader does a company need in each phase?** Jobs built it. Cook scaled it. What does Ternus inherit?
- 3 **Is Apple still in the AI race?** Siri, Apple Intelligence, Vision Pro — ahead or behind, and does a hardware CEO change the answer?

TEAM PRESENTATION: 4CUZ

TEAM PRESENTATION: VOUCH

THREE SKILLS THAT FAIL SEPARATELY

| PITCHING IS THREE PROBLEMS

NARRATIVE

What's the story?
What's the arc? Why
should anyone care?

DECK

The artifact you build to
carry the narrative.
Slide-by-slide.

ACCESS

How you get that
narrative + deck in
front of the people who
matter.

Work them in that order. First the story, then the artifact, then how you get it in the room.

PART 1: THE NARRATIVE

A PITCH IS NOT A BRIEFING.

 Summary  Feature list  Product explainer

Pitches are narratives that inspire people to action.

| A FRAMEWORK FOR NARRATIVES

ANDY RASKIN'S STRATEGIC NARRATIVE

Five elements. Used by Zuora, Drift, Salesforce, and hundreds of others. Battle-tested on the world's hardest audiences.

→ ["The Greatest Sales Deck I've Ever Seen"](#)

We'll walk through all five. Then we'll look at how to *open*, because the opening is where most first-time founders get it wrong.

| RASKIN'S FIVE ELEMENTS

1 Name a big change in the world — your problem, reframed as a shift

2 Show there'll be winners and losers — stakes

3 Tease the promised land — desirable, hard to reach alone

4 Features as magic gifts — each one overcomes an obstacle

5 Present evidence — customer stories, metrics, demos

RASKIN ELEMENT 1: CHANGE IN THE WORLD

Raskin is about how you *open* with your problem — package it so the investor leans in instead of leaning out.

STATIC PROBLEM STATEMENT

"Hospitals lose medical equipment all the time."

SAME PROBLEM, REFRAMED AS CHANGE

"Hospital M&A has tripled in three years. Inventory systems weren't built for that."

The problem hasn't changed. The opening move has.

| RASKIN ELEMENT 2: STAKES

Once you've named the change, make the consequences real.

"Companies that move fast will capture this market. Companies that don't will be consolidated or displaced within 5 years."

The investor should be thinking: *which side of this do I want to be on?*

RASKIN ELEMENT 3: THE PROMISED LAND

Before you show your solution, show the desired future state.



Raskin's rule: the promised land must be *desirable and difficult for the prospect to reach without outside help*.

If the audience can imagine getting there on their own, you haven't described a compelling enough promised land.

RASKIN ELEMENT 4: FEATURES AS MAGIC GIFTS

Don't list features. Frame each one as a gift that overcomes a specific obstacle between here and the promised land.

FEATURE LIST

"AI-powered matching. Real-time alerts. Dashboard analytics."

GIFT FRAMING

"Matching that reflects who your team already trusts — no more cold applicants with fake LinkedIns."

| RASKIN ELEMENT 5: EVIDENCE

Customer stories. Metrics. Demos.

You've promised a land. Now prove people can get there.



For Demo Day: your real users who signed up, the quote from one of them, the moment they said "where has this been?" — that's your evidence.

THREE FORMATS — NOT SHORTER VERSIONS OF EACH OTHER

Three answers to "what do you do?" Have all three ready. Working through them sharpens your narrative.

ONE SENTENCE

Job: create a mental model.

Context: elevator, intro, "so what do you do?"

ONE PARAGRAPH

Job: earn a meeting.

Context: cold email, intro request, "send me a summary."

DECK OPENER

Job: emotional transportation.

Context: first 60 seconds of the live pitch.

| FROM NARRATIVE TO DECK

Your narrative is the argument. Your deck is the artifact that carries it.

NARRATIVE

The story arc — why now, who's affected, what changes, why you. Lives in your head and your script.

DECK

The visual sequence that carries the narrative. Slide by slide. The story tells you which slides you need and in what order.

Don't build the deck first. Build the narrative first — then let it dictate the structure.

PART 2: THE DECK

SEVEN SLIDES EVERY TEMPLATE AGREES ON

1 Problem

2 Solution

3 Market

4 Business Model

5 Competition

6 Team

7 The Ask

SLIDE-BY-SLIDE: WHAT GOES ON EACH

| COVER / TITLE

Job: give the investor a mental model in 5 seconds. Every slide after this will be filtered through how they understood this one.

INCLUDE

- › Company name
- › One sentence: what you do, for whom

CUT

- › Taglines like "the future of X"
- › "The Uber of Y"
- › Your logo at 500px

The one-liner on this slide is the most important sentence in your deck. If you can't say what you do in 15 words, the mental model won't form.

THE CUSTOMER IS THE HERO. YOU ARE THE GUIDE.

*Most first-time founders make themselves the protagonist.
That's backwards.*

| HERO VS. GUIDE

FOUNDER-AS-HERO (WEAK)

- › "We saw a broken market and decided to fix it"
- › "We built something nobody else had the vision to build"
- › "Our journey began when..."

CUSTOMER-AS-HERO (STRONG)

- › "Jen is a recruiter with 400 open reqs and no way to tell which candidates her team already trusts"
- › "Before us, Jen did X. Now she does Y."
- › The transformation is in the *customer*

| SLIDE 1: PROBLEM

Job: make the investor feel the pain. A great problem slide makes them nod — they recognize the reality you're describing. This is where you prove you've talked to real people.

INCLUDE

- › A specific pain, for a specific person, in a specific context
- › Why current solutions *fall short* — not that they don't exist

CUT

- › Abstract market conditions
- › Your company name (this slide is about the customer)
- › "Consumers demand better experiences" (everyone does)

| WHY NOW

The most skipped slide. Also the most powerful when done well.

THREE TO FIVE TIMESTAMPED EXTERNAL CONDITIONS

- › A declining cost curve
- › A regulatory change
- › A behavior shift
- › A new enabling technology
- › A consumer psychology shift

Sequoia's sharp version: "Nature hates a vacuum. Why hasn't your solution been built before^{25 / 66} now?"

I "BECAUSE AI" IS NOT A WHY NOW

Vague AI reasoning is the 2026 version of "because the cloud."

VAGUE

"AI is transforming everything and we're riding that wave."

SPECIFIC

"The cost of a single LLM inference dropped 85% in 18 months. A workflow that was \$40 per user/month is now \$2. Our business model didn't exist two years ago."

| SLIDE 2: SOLUTION

Job: connect your mechanism directly to slide 1's pain. The investor should be able to draw a line from the problem you described to exactly what your product does about it. Investors spend about 33 seconds here — clarity beats completeness.

INCLUDE

- › What your product actually *does*
- › The core mechanism
- › Why it's **better**, not just different

CUT

- › Feature lists ("Intuitive. Powerful. Scalable.")
- › Technical architecture diagrams
- › Product roadmap

| SLIDE 3: MARKET

Job: convince the investor the opportunity is big enough. Use *both* approaches — top-down for credibility and research context, bottom-up to show you've thought through the business model.

TOP-DOWN

"The global recruiting market is \$215 billion."

Establishes credibility. Shows you know the space. Gives investors a familiar frame of reference.

BOTTOM-UP

"31,000 mid-size US companies × 12 reqs × \$2,400/req/year = \$890M addressable."

Shows business model thinking. Every number is defensible. Proves the math works.

Lead with top-down for scale, then ground it with bottom-up math.

| PRODUCT

Job: prove the thing exists and works. This is the "show don't tell" moment. One well-chosen screenshot should make your UX legible in 3 seconds — the investor should immediately see what the user sees and understand why it's valuable.

KEEP

- › One hero screen showing the core action
- › One sentence of caption
- › Annotations if the value isn't visually obvious

CUT

- › A full product tour or six screenshots
- › Marketing copy ("Intuitive. Powerful.")
- › Anything requiring more than a 3-second glance

| SLIDE 4: BUSINESS MODEL

Job: prove the economics work. Investors need to understand the payment structure and unit economics before they can evaluate the investment — not just who uses the product, but who pays, what they pay for, and whether the margins are viable. DocSend: investors spend **94% more time** on this slide in decks they go on to fund.

ANSWER THESE

- › Who **pays** (not who uses)?
- › What do they pay for, and how often?
- › Rough unit economics: LTV, CAC, payback period
- › Gross margins — this tells them

CUT

- › 5-year revenue projections (save those for Financials)
- › Vague pricing ("TBD" or "enterprise pricing")
- › "We'll figure out monetization at scale"

| TRACTION

IF YOU HAVE REVENUE

- › MRR / ARR
- › Growth rate MoM
- › Customer count
- › Retention

IF YOU'RE PRE-REVENUE

- › Active users, engagement
- › Waitlist depth
- › Signed pilots, LOIs
- › Notable partnerships



Show the slope, not the point. \$50K MRR growing 25% MoM beats flat \$500K MRR.

| SLIDE 5: COMPETITION

Job: show you've mapped the landscape honestly and you have a defensible wedge. Investors see hundreds of decks — they always know competitors exist. Acknowledging them shows market sophistication; ignoring them signals naivety.

INCLUDE

- › Direct competitors
- › Indirect alternatives
- › **The status quo** (Excel, email, doing nothing)
- › Why you're different *and* defensible

CUT

- › "No competition" (always wrong)
- › The 2×2 where you're alone in the upper-right
- › Dismissing incumbents without explaining their constraints

"NO COMPETITION" IS NEVER THE RIGHT ANSWER

WHAT YOU MEAN

"No one is doing exactly what we're doing."

WHAT AN INVESTOR HEARS

- › "They don't understand their market"
- › "They haven't talked to customers"
- › "Either this isn't real or it's not defensible"



Hunter Walk's test: what would your competitors say about this slide? If you can't defend the axes, leave it out

| SLIDE 6: TEAM

Job: answer "why these people, for this problem?" Investors are often backing the team as much as the idea. The single most important signal is specific domain experience that makes you uniquely positioned to solve this — not that you're smart or passionate.

INCLUDE

- › Founders + key leadership
- › Photos, short titles
- › **"Why this person, for this problem"**
- › Specific domain experience that matters here

CUT

- › Generic "passionate / experienced / driven"
- › Advisors standing in for founders
- › Companies you briefly worked at but didn't do the thing

| SLIDE 7: THE ASK

Job: make it easy for an interested investor to say yes. Be specific about what you need, how you'll deploy it, and what milestones it buys. Vagueness signals you haven't thought through the raise.

ANSWER THESE

- › How much are you raising?
- › At what stage (pre-seed, seed)?
- › How will the capital deploy?
(product, sales, hiring)
- › What milestones does this enable?
- › How much runway does it buy?

CUT

- › Vague "we're looking for strategic partners"
- › No number at all
- › A use-of-funds pie chart with no milestones attached

LIVE PITCH ≠ SENT DECK

| TWO ARTIFACTS, NOT ONE

The "universal deck fallacy" is the #1 first-time-founder mistake. The deck you pitch from is not the deck you send.

	Live pitch deck	Sent / leave-behind deck
Slides	10–12	15–20
Text per slide	Near-zero; readable in 3 seconds	Full sentences; headlines state conclusions
Function	Reinforces your voice	Stands alone as a visual white paper
Core risk	Slides compete with your voice	Too sparse to survive without you

| THE FOLLOW-UP MISTAKE

WHAT MOST FOUNDERS SEND

The same minimal live deck — big images, one-word slides, no context. Partners who weren't in the room can't evaluate it.

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEND

The reading deck: full sentences, headlines that state conclusions, stands alone without your voice.

 **Rule:** always send the *reading* deck as follow-up. Two artifacts, not one.

| WHERE THE TEMPLATES DISAGREE



WHY NOW

Only Sequoia dedicates a slide. Everyone else folds it in. First-time founders consistently skip it.



TEAM PLACEMENT

Conventional templates put Team at slide 6 or beyond. Thiel and NFX put it at 2–3. The data says earlier.



SLIDE COUNT

Kawasaki: 10. NFX: ~15. The DocSend data: 15–20 beats very short or very long decks.

WHAT INVESTORS ACTUALLY DO WITH YOUR DECK

| DOCSEND'S 2024 DATA

3:44

AVERAGE TIME ON A FUNDED DECK

2:31

COLD DECK READ TIME

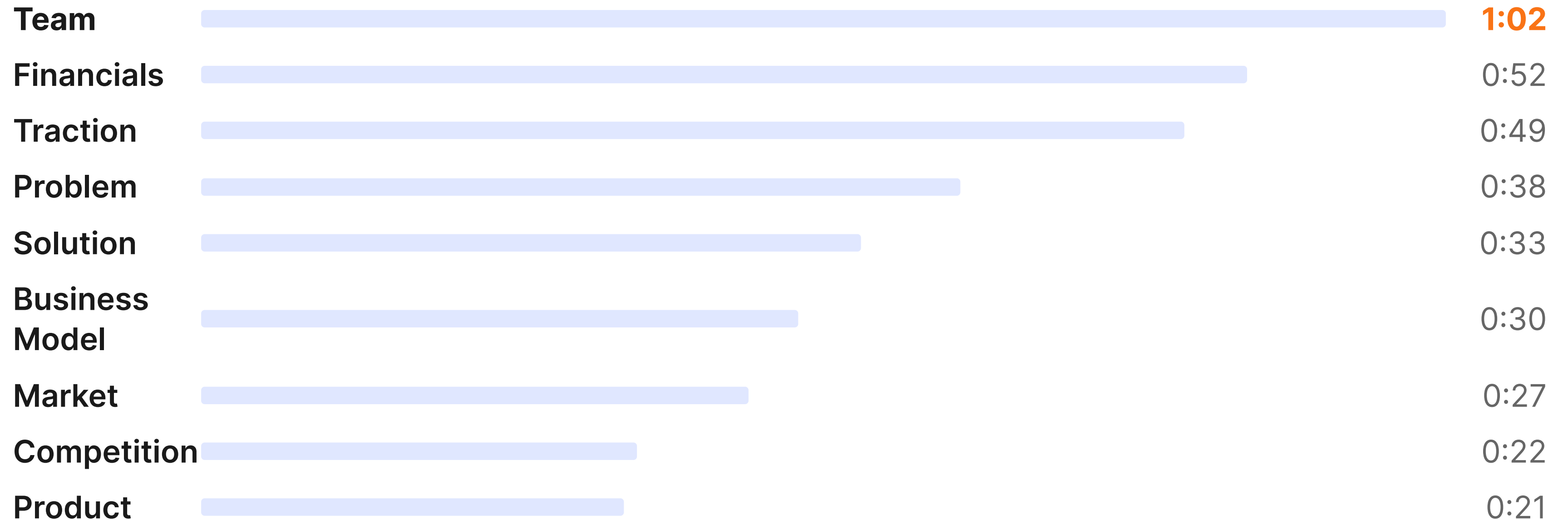
4:18

WARM DECK READ TIME

Funded decks get ~4 minutes of attention on first read. That's a *skim*. Every slide needs to earn its place.

Source: [DocSend via PitchGrade](#)

| PER-SLIDE ATTENTION (FUNDED DECKS)



Slide 6 (Team) gets **3x the attention** of the product slide.

TEAM GETS THE MOST INVESTOR ATTENTION

1:02

TEAM SLIDE

0:21

PRODUCT SLIDE

0:38

PROBLEM SLIDE



Most templates put Team at slide 6 or later. If your team is the strongest reason to back you, consider moving it to position 2 or 3.

| SLIDE COUNT REALITY

Guy Kawasaki wrote "10 slides" in 2005 — for a projector in a conference room.

Today's decks are read async on laptops. Research from DocSend and Harvard: decks in the **11–20 slide range outperform** decks that are too short or too long.



For Demo Day: aim for 10–12 slides in the live deck, 15–20 in the leave-behind.

WHAT THE FAMOUS DECKS TEACH

| CANONICAL DECKS — CLICK TO OPEN

LinkedIn Series B

Reid Hoffman's annotated deck — reidhoffman.org

Airbnb 2009 Seed

12 slides. The most studied seed deck in history.

Front Series A

Mathilde Collin published it herself with annotations — [Medium](#)

Dropbox — Startup Lessons Learned

Drew Houston on how Dropbox grew — [SlideShare](#)

| LEAD WITH THE HARDEST OBJECTION

The best decks identify the single hardest question about their business and address it *early*.

- › **LinkedIn (Series B):** "How will LinkedIn make money?" → slide 2
- › **Buffer (seed):** led with paying customers before anything else
- › **Facebook (2004):** led with 65% daily unique user rate

Each founder identified the #1 objection *for their specific business* and structured around it.

| BREAKING THE 10-SLIDE RULE IS FINE

LINKEDIN

38

slides + appendix
(sophisticated leave-
behind)

YOUTUBE

10

slides
(Sequoia already knew
them)

BUFFER

13

slides
(right for a traction story)

The rule is a heuristic. The story dictates the count.

PART 3: ACCESS

YOUR NARRATIVE AND DECK DON'T | MATTER IF NO ONE SEES THEM

DEMO DAY

The audience comes to you. Access is built into the format — your job is just to be ready with a strong narrative and a polished deck.

| THE ACCESS MATH

40–50%

WARM INTROS → FIRST MEETING

1–5%

COLD EMAILS → FIRST MEETING

Your deck almost never earns the meeting on its own. The **relationship** earns the meeting; the **deck** survives it.

Sources: [DocSend](#), [Paul Graham](#)

| MAP YOUR INTRO GRAPH

Before you start pitching for real, sit down with a spreadsheet and list:

- 1 Every person you know who **knows investors**
- 2 Every **Columbia alum** working at a VC firm
- 3 Every **founder you could reach** whose company was backed by a VC on your target list
- 4 Every **customer** of yours who knows an investor

This is tedious — which is exactly why most first-time founders skip it, and why doing it is an advantage.

THE FIRST CHECK IS HALF THE WORK.

Once one credible investor commits, the rest follow. — Paul Graham

TREAT EVERY "MAYBE" AS A NO UNTIL A SAFE IS SIGNED

All of these are functionally passes:

- › "We love what you're building"
- › "Let's keep talking"
- › "Can you send me your deck?" (after they've already seen it)
- › "Circle back when you have a lead"
- › "I have a lot going on"

| COLUMBIA-SPECIFIC ACCESS

- › **Columbia Startup Lab** — SoHo residency for Columbia-alum-founded startups
- › **Columbia Venture Community** — alumni angel network + incubator programs
- › **Almaworks / Columbia Venture Competition** — up to \$250K non-dilutive
- › **Dorm Room Fund** (run by First Round) — operates at Columbia
- › **NYC seed funds** — Primary, Lerer Hippeau, Box Group, RRE, Notation, Compound

A Columbia email to a Columbia alum at a VC is a *semi-warm cold email*. Use it.

| ACCESS, TL;DR

1 Warm intros, not cold email, get meetings

2 Build your **intro graph** before you need it

3 Run investors **in parallel**, not serial

4 The **first check** unlocks the rest

5 "**Maybe**" is no until the SAFE is signed

FOR DEMO DAY SPECIFICALLY

| THE DEMO DAY FORMAT

LENGTH

- › **8 min** — pitch
- › **4 min** — Q&A
- › **2 min** — transition

AUDIENCE

Peers, faculty, and visiting industry leaders and alumni.

ARTIFACT

A live deck you present from, plus a leave-behind you send after.

WHAT TO EMPHASIZE GIVEN THIS AUDIENCE

- › **Real users** — you've been acquiring them all semester. Lead with numbers.
- › **Specific transformation** — what a user does now vs. before
- › **Your insight** — what did you learn that the room hasn't?
- › **The pivot story** (if you had one) — what did you learn, what did you change
- › **A clear ask** — even if it's "we're looking for our first 100 users," name it

| WHAT TO CUT

- › Your "founding story" (unless it's unusually load-bearing)
- › The full product tour
- › Architecture diagrams
- › Roadmap beyond 6 months
- › Hockey-stick projections

An 8-minute pitch is ~1,200 words. That's two typed pages. Treat it like an essay where every paragraph has to do real work.

YOUR ASSIGNMENT

DUE TUESDAY, APRIL 28 (START OF CLASS)

FIRST DRAFT OF YOUR PITCH DECK

10–12 slides. Submitted as a PDF. One per team.

FINAL ROUND OF USER TESTING

Reach out to real users. Capture pull quotes your deck can use.

| ONE MORE ROUND OF REAL USERS

- › Product is frozen — now go **use it with real people**
- › Target **3–5 users** per team (outside your team, outside the class)
- › Watch them try the product. Listen more than you talk.
- › Get their **permission to quote them** (name + role, or initials + role)

A live quote from a real user is worth more than any line you can write about yourselves.

| WHAT MAKES A PULL QUOTE USABLE

GOOD

- › Specific — names the problem or the moment of relief
- › In their words, not yours
- › Attributed (name + role, or role + context)
- › Short enough to live on a slide

SKIP

- › "This is great" / "I love it"
- › Generic praise with no detail
- › Anonymous with no context
- › Anything you had to coach them into saying

Drop quotes on your Problem, Solution, and Traction slides. One sharp quote beats a paragraph of your own copy.

| WHAT YOUR DRAFT MUST INCLUDE

- 1 Title / cover
- 2 Opening slide — **Raskin-style change statement**
- 3 Problem
- 4 Why Now
- 5 Solution
- 6 Product (GIF, video, or live walkthrough of your biggest aha moment)
- 7 Market Size (bottom-up)
- 8 Traction (show the slope)
- 9 Business Model
- 10 Competition (including status quo)
- 11 Team (move it earlier if it's load-bearing)
- 12 The Ask

Submit both: a *live pitch deck* (10–12 slides) and a *leave-behind deck* (15–20 slides). See the ^{65 / 66}

END OF CLASS 24

Next: Feature freeze (Thu Apr 23)